

UTI pitch deck

PITCH — UTI — VERDICT

ADJUDICATED 2026-08-07 — DECLINE the long at \$29.12 on two legs (the company cut its *underlying* profit power, not just its growth spending, and it broke its own credibility by reaffirming guidance three months before cutting it); this is not a short, and the case reopens only at or below \$21.

Status at pack build (2026-08-31): \$21.13, 1.3% above a fresh 52-week low of \$20.85, 58.8% below the 52-week high. No position, no orders. The reopen price is 0.6% away and has not been touched.

Reaching it authorizes re-derivation of the case, not a purchase.

What we believe

Universal Technical Institute trains automotive, diesel, and skilled-trades technicians, plus allied-health workers through its Concorde segment. On 5 August 2026 it released fiscal Q3 and cut guidance for the first time in the company's recent history, three months after reaffirming it. The stock fell 34.2% the next day (from \$42.37 to \$27.87 on 6.8M shares against a normal ~600k) and has fallen another 24.2% in the eighteen sessions since, with no new company news.

What we believe, stated plainly:

- 1. The cut was to earning power, not to a spending choice.** The company kept two profit lines: a “reported” adjusted EBITDA number (which includes a large growth-investment charge) and a “baseline” number that strips that charge out. It cut *both*. Reported went from \$114–119M to \$100–103M. Baseline — the ex-investment engine — went from “>\$155M” to “>\$135M”, roughly a 13% cut. Growth spending is reversible and therefore not a valuation event. A 13% cut to the engine underneath it is. This is the single load-bearing fact of the case, and it survived both benches intact.
- 2. The credibility break is real and separate.** Management reaffirmed on 6 May and cut on 5 August. A first-ever cut that closely follows a reaffirmation earns a permanent discount on future guidance, independent of the operating facts.
- 3. Enrollment quality is deteriorating, and nobody is talking about it.** The bad-debt provision in the cash-flow statement rose 48.7%, against \$52.1M of notes receivable the company holds itself. Because of the “90/10” rule (a school must draw at least 10% of revenue from non-federal sources), institutional lending to students is structurally required, not optional — so a rising provision is a cost of doing business that scales with enrollment, and it is rising faster than enrollment.

4. **But the “this company is executing badly” framing is wrong.** That was the original diagnosis, and the blue bench overturned it. Concorde showed leads up 22% while starts fell 1.4% — which reads as a company-specific failure until you look at the peer. Lincoln Educational (LINC) reported the *identical* shape in the same window: starts up only 1%, “short of expectations due to lower conversion rates,” with management explicitly blaming AI answer engines — “AI models providing simplistic comparisons that may highlight lower-cost options like community colleges.” Two independent operators, same quarter, same leads-up/conversion-down break. That is a sector-wide change in how prospective students search, not one management team fumbling.
5. **So the honest position is: the diagnosis is a sector channel shock we can name but cannot yet measure, layered on a company that just proved its baseline can step down. That is a reason to watch, not to own.** The adjudication declined, and it declined for the right reason: we do not know whether \$135M is the new floor or the first step down.

What the market believes

The market believes what the print said, because the print said it out loud. There is no hidden information here — the guidance cut, the “now expected” starts revision, the growth-spend framing, and the reaffirm-then-cut sequence are all in a public 8-K that anyone can read. The 34% one-day move was the market pricing a disclosure, correctly and immediately.

What the market appears to believe *beyond* that, judging by the further 24% slide on no news:

- That \$135M baseline is not a floor. The tape is treating the cut as the first of a series, not a one-quarter timing artifact.
- That the capital plan is now suspect. The company is spending ~\$110M of capex in a year in which it generated \$17.4M of operating cash over nine months — free cash flow of roughly negative \$65–68M — and it refinanced into a \$200M secured revolver in the middle of the drawdown.
- That the demand channel is structurally impaired, not cyclically soft. If the market has read the LINC call, it is pricing a permanent hit to lead-to-enrollment conversion across the whole for-profit trade-school category.

The market is not, as far as we can tell, distinguishing between “UTI executed badly” and “the category’s funnel broke.” It is simply selling. That is the only place a difference of opinion could live.

Why we might have edge

Four candidates, ranked by how much of them is actually ours:

1. **The peer read-across (genuinely ours, and it flipped our own conclusion).** Reading LINC’s Q2 against UTI’s Q3 converts a company-specific execution kill into a sector mechanism with a named cause. Almost no secondary coverage joined those two prints. This is the strongest original work in the file — and note that it works *against* the harshest version of our own case, which is the kind of finding worth trusting.

2. **The baseline-versus-reported split (partly ours).** The headline framing was “\$9.0M of strategic growth expenses.” The baseline cut sits in a supplemental slide and a transcript bridge, not the headline. Anyone reading only the press release comes away with the flattering half of the story. Extracting the baseline cut required joining the deck to the call. That said, once a stock is down 58%, assume the professional holders found it too — this is a timing edge measured in days, not a persistent one.
3. **The provision line (ours, and still unpriced as far as we can tell).** A 48.7% jump in the bad-debt provision appears in no coverage we found. It is small in dollars today and matters only as a leading indicator of enrollment quality.
4. **The lender vote (ours by timing).** Eleven days after the cut, five banks — Fifth Third, JPMorgan, Truist, Citibank and PNC — replaced the company’s entire credit facility with a \$200M secured revolver plus \$75M of uncommitted incremental capacity, maturing August 2031, interest-only ([8-K filed 2026-08-18](#)). Five lenders did that diligence with the cut guidance and the negative free cash flow in hand. That removes the refinancing tail from the bear case. It does not make the equity cheap; it makes bankruptcy risk not the question.

Honest ceiling on all of this: none of these is a divergence from a stated market view, because we never pulled one. Neither bench obtained the post-cut street FY27 EBITDA or EPS number. We rejected on the *level* of the valuation, not on a named gap between our forecast and someone else’s. Until that number is in hand, “edge” here is a claim about reading quality, not a measured disagreement.

Why it might be priced in

Most of it is, and we should say so directly.

- **The cut is public.** Both benches tagged the central findings — the cut, the de-rate, the credibility break — as consensus. Any reader of the print has them.
- **The 34% gap was arithmetically fair.** The move decomposes almost exactly to the guidance change. That is the market working, not the market erring.
- **After a 58% fall it is not obviously cheap.** At \$21.13 the enterprise value is about \$1.15B against roughly \$10M of net cash. That is 11.4× the new reported EBITDA guide, 8.5–8.7× the baseline guide, and 33–37× the guided EPS of \$0.57–0.64. It has moved from *very expensive* (53–60× guided earnings pre-print) to *ordinary*. Ordinary is not a thesis.
- **The tape has not stabilized.** Eighteen sessions after the gap, volume is still 2–4× normal and the stock is making new lows. This is a security still being repriced, not one that has been washed out and forgotten. Buying into that is buying into other people’s ongoing decision-making.
- **The best-informed holder left first.** Coliseum Capital, the long-standing strategic holder, block-sold roughly 3.0M shares at \$41.40 on 8 June and filed an exit — eight weeks before the cut ([SC 13D/A](#)). The only post-crash insider purchase we can confirm is a director buying 1,000 shares for about \$21,800 on 25 August ([Form 4](#)). \$21.8k of buying against ~\$124M of selling is not a signal; it is a gesture.

The strongest version of “it’s priced in”: this was a cause-of-move question, the cause is fully disclosed, and the cause is fully adverse. Nothing here requires the market to be wrong.

What could go wrong

Assume for this section that the \$21 gate trips, the re-derivation comes back constructive, and we buy a starter. Here is how that ends badly.

Failure 1 — The baseline steps down again, and 8.5× becomes 11×. (Tripwire exists.) The whole constructive case rests on “>\$135M” being a floor. If the high-school automotive/diesel funnel is still shrinking when FY27 guidance is set, the baseline guide comes in at \$110–125M and the multiple we thought we were paying was never the multiple. We would be down 25–35% from the entry with the stock at genuine new lows and no argument left. *Monitorable*: the FY27 baseline guide at the year-end print is the exact number, and the named exit is a guide below \$150M.

Failure 2 — The heroic fourth quarter doesn’t show up, and the capital plan collides with the cash. (Tripwire exists.) Nine-month operating cash flow was \$17.4M against \$80.9M of capex plus \$4.5M of intangibles. Hitting the full-year cash plan implies something on the order of \$79.6M of operating cash flow in a single quarter. If that lands at \$45M instead, the company is funding a \$110M buildout off a revolver with \$160M already drawn while the engine servicing it has just been cut 13%. That is not a solvency event — the new facility runs to 2031 and has undrawn committed capacity — but it is a forced-humility event: capex gets cut, growth gets deferred, and the growth story that justified the multiple disappears. *Monitorable*: Q4 operating cash flow and the FY27 capex guide, both at the year-end print.

Failure 3 — The funnel is permanently intermediated, and we cannot see it until the operators tell us. (NO MONITORABLE TRIPWIRE.) LINC named the mechanism: generative answer engines now sit between a prospective student and a school, summarizing options and steering toward cheaper community-college alternatives. If that is a structural re-rating of customer acquisition for the entire category, then leads-up/conversion-down is the new steady state, advertising cost per start ratchets up permanently (Concorde’s is already +30.5%), and every operator’s “baseline” is on a slow escalator downward.

We have no instrument that observes this. There is no public series for search intermediation, no filing that discloses it, no vendor feed we subscribe to that measures answer-engine share of a consumer funnel. The desk’s closest connector observes app-review velocity, which is adjacent at best. We would learn about it only the way we learned about it this time — from an operator saying it on a call, one quarter after it hit the P&L, i.e. after the stock has already moved.

Unknown-unknown class: unobservable channel intermediation. A change in the distribution layer between a company and its customers, where the layer itself publishes no data, discloses no share, and is not a counterparty to anyone who files. This class also covers platform-algorithm changes, app-store ranking shifts, and payer/broker steering. Our entire detector library is built on things that leave a paper or pixel trail — filings, permits, satellite imagery, court dockets, review feeds. An intermediation shock leaves none of those. We should treat any thesis whose demand side runs through a consumer

search funnel as carrying an unhedgeable, unmeasurable term, and size accordingly. A second, smaller member of the same class here: the regulatory tests (gainful employment debt-to-earnings, 90/10) whose pass/fail we could not verify from public filings — we flagged that as unverifiable rather than clean.

The reflexive and structural leg — our own footprint, our own flow, our own rules.

- *Our size is not the problem.* UTI trades roughly 1.4–2.5M shares a day, about \$30–50M of notional. A 0.5%-of-book starter is a rounding error against that. Liquidity is not a constraint on entry or exit, and we should not pretend otherwise to manufacture caution.
- *Our gate design is the problem.* The reopen price of \$21 sits 1.3% above a 52-week low that the stock is actively making, on volume still running 2–4× normal. Our own rule therefore schedules our bid into precisely the zone where whatever selling is still working is still working. We would be buying into predicted flow, not away from it. The gate was set by the harsher bench as a level below which the case deserved *re-derivation*; it was never a level at which the stock became attractive. The adjudication said this explicitly — “reaching it authorizes work, not size” — and the risk is that a trigger firing *feels* like a decision.
- *Our doctrine pulls the same direction as the falling knife.* We have a standing default that a clean adversarial court with no named killer resolves to a minimum starter rather than to flat. That default exists to stop us from talking ourselves out of everything. Here, two named killers exist and the adjudication used them, so the default does not apply — but the gravitational pull toward “just take a starter” is real, and it points at the same price the tape is falling through. The two pressures are not independent, and if we buy, we will have bought because two of our own rules pointed at the same number at the same moment.
- *Tax interaction.* A starter bought at the gate would be a short-term lot with a named exit at the November print, roughly eleven weeks later. If the exit fires, we realize a short-term loss — usable, and not a reason to avoid the trade. If it works, we would be sitting on a short-term gain with a decision about whether to hold for the long-term clock, which is exactly the kind of tax-tail-wagging-the-thesis situation we try to avoid designing into a position at entry.

If this position loses money, the most likely reason will be that we bought a broken customer-acquisition channel that we mistook for a temporary spending decision — the high-school automotive and diesel funnel keeps shrinking as answer engines steer students elsewhere, the “baseline” profit line steps down a second time at the FY27 guide, and 8.5× on \$135M turns out to have been 11× on \$105M.

What we checked ourselves

Including, explicitly, where our own analysts got it wrong.

Claim	How checked	Found	Confirmed?
The 34% gap was a mispricing to buy	Daily bars vs the 5 Aug 8-K	8/5 close \$42.37 → 8/6 close \$27.87 (−34.22%) on 6.82M shares vs ~600k normal, the session after the release. The tape repriced a disclosure.	No — refuted. There was no dislocation on day one.

Claim	How checked	Found	Confirmed?
The cut is just discretionary growth spending	8-K exhibit 99.1 vs the Q2 supplement	Reported adj. EBITDA \$114–119M → \$100–103M, <i>and</i> baseline (ex-investment) “>\$155M” → “>\$135M”. Both cut. Starts outlook revised down (“now expected to be between 31,900 and 32,300”).	Yes — the bear leg holds.
The press release and the call tell the same story	Release text vs call coverage	The vetted release attributes the shortfall to “\$9.0 million in strategic growth expenses”; the call attributes roughly 70% of the full-year EBITDA reduction to weaker Q4 high-school-channel automotive/diesel starts. The written document is silent on the demand cause.	Partly. The document’s silence is confirmed from primary; the 70% split rests on secondary coverage, not a transcript we read ourselves.
It’s cheap after a 58% fall	10-Q supplement + live tape	Net cash ~\$10M; EV ~\$1.15B; 11.4× reported EBITDA guide, 8.5–8.7× baseline, 33–37× guided EPS. Pre-print it was 53–60× guided EPS.	Yes — this is a de-rate off an extreme multiple, not a fall to value.
The strategic holder is still alongside us	SEC 13D/A + Rule 144 notices	Coliseum block-sold ~3.0M shares at \$41.40 on 6/8 and filed an exit; three 144 notices in June preceded it.	No — they left, at the high, eight weeks early.
Insiders are buying the crash	Form 4s	One director, 1,000 shares, \$21.765, on 8/25 (~\$21.8k).	No. Token, not a signal.
Solvency is the risk	10-Q + 8/18 8-K	Nine-month FCF ≈ –\$65 to –\$68M, but the 8/12 refinancing gives a \$200M revolver plus \$75M incremental to Aug 2031 from five banks.	No — correctly <i>not</i> escalated to fatal. The bearish bench declined to overstate this, which was the right call.
Exit liquidity is a constraint	Daily bars	\$30–50M notional per day.	No. The bearish bench explicitly declined to manufacture this kill. Worth noting as good conduct.
BENCH ERROR — the peer discriminator	LINC Q2 2026, reported the same week	The bearish bench pre-committed to a test: <i>if LINC raises, UTI’s problem is execution; if LINC struggles, it’s the sector</i> . LINC reaffirmed rather than raised , posted starts +1% “short of expectations due to lower conversion rates,” and blamed AI answer engines. Its EBITDA growth decelerated from +85% to +42.4%.	The bench’s own trigger resolved against the bench. The “company-specific execution failure” framing is overturned.
BENCH ERROR — stale price	Pack tape vs the bench’s mark	The whole valuation leg was computed at a \$27.88–29.12 stock and applied to a \$21.13 tape. At the lower price the name sits <i>below</i> two of the bench’s own profitable comparables and roughly at the peer median. Year-to-date is about –19%, not the +6.7% the bench cited.	Confirmed stale. Three findings dependent on price were invalidated by the tape.

Claim	How checked	Found	Confirmed?
BENCH ERROR — coverage gap, self-reported	—	Neither bench pulled the post-cut street FY27 EBITDA or EPS. We rejected on absolute level, never on a named divergence from a stated consensus. Both benches reported this rather than hiding it.	Confirmed gap. Work owed.
BENCH ERROR — the constructive bench overreached	Adjudication	The constructive bench ruled to advance a 0.5% starter at ≤\$21.25. The adjudication overruled it: the valuation leg being stale does not repair the baseline-cut leg or the credibility leg, and “cheaper than last week” is not “cheap.”	Adjudication stands. DECLINE.
PACK ERROR — market cap	Pack vs 10-Q share count × live tape	The pack carried \$1.53B, which prices ~55.1M shares at the 8/6 close, not at the live quote. True market cap ≈ \$1.16B.	Confirmed pack error, caught and superseded from primary.
PACK ERROR — stale fundamentals	Pack XBRL vs filings	The quarterly series ends 2025-06-30 — a full year stale, and it omits the entire quarter that caused the crash. The ocf tag also disagrees in concept and scale with the operating-cash-flow figures used in the analysis (\$22.96M vs \$97.33M for adjacent years).	Confirmed. Unresolved — the cash-flow reconciliation is still owed.
Deceleration in active students (+12.7% → +5.8%) is real, not seasonal	Seasonality tool	Not run — no shell available to the bench.	Plausible, not confirmed. Reported, not skipped.
Post-crash Form 4s (8/12, 8/14, 8/27) were open-market purchases	EDGAR	EDGAR returned 403; the proxy returned no filer detail. Direction unknown — could be grants, tax withholding, or buys.	Unverified. Do not cite as an insider signal in either direction.

Two notes on method, for the record. Every SEC document in this file was fetched through a proxy after sec.gov returned 403 to direct requests. And the live price rests on the pack’s gateway quote cross-checked against an independent daily-bar vendor series agreeing to the cent — not on a fresh gateway pull, which was blocked this session.

PROPOSED ENTRY BANDS

There is no entry. The adjudication declined the long and did not authorize a short. No position, no orders, nothing staged. What follows are the reopen conditions, reproduced from the adjudication rather than re-derived, because inventing our own would defeat the purpose of having had a court.

Reopen conditions (verbatim from the adjudication):

1. **Price at or below \$21.00 → re-derive the whole case.** Not a buy trigger. Touching \$21 authorizes a fresh court with fresh numbers; it authorizes work, not size. Current price \$21.13 —

the gate is 0.6% away and has never traded. Note the design flaw honestly: this level sits 0.7% above the 52-week low of \$20.85 on a tape that is still making lows, so it will fire into active selling. The re-derivation must therefore start by asking whether the stock has stabilized, not by asking whether the price is low.

2. **Q1 FY27 starts at or above +12% → the flip path activates.** This is the demand test. It cannot resolve before the Q1 print (early February 2027). A starts number at or above +12% would mean the high-school channel is re-accelerating and the baseline cut was a timing artifact.
3. **LINC Q2 (2026-08-10) as the sector-versus-execution discriminator.** If LINC absorbed its smaller drag and raised, the execution-gap case against UTI strengthens; if LINC cut too, the problem is the sector and the case against UTI softens. **This has resolved and the standing sensor list has not been updated: LINC reaffirmed rather than raising, with starts +1%, conversion-driven weakness, and management naming AI answer engines as the cause. That is the “sector, not execution” branch. The case softens on this leg.** Two of the three legs of the decline (baseline cut, credibility) are untouched by it.

If, and only if, a re-derivation at or below \$21 comes back constructive, the constructive bench’s proposal was: 0.5% of the book as a minimum starter, entry at or below \$21.25, no addition above \$23 before the year-end print, held as a diligence position rather than a conviction one, with a named exit — **full exit if the FY27 baseline adjusted EBITDA guide comes in below \$150M at the year-end print, or if the FY26 provision exceeds 3.4% of revenue.** That proposal was overruled at \$21.13 and is recorded here as the shape a future entry would take, not as an authorization. It expires if the tape moves materially away from \$21 in either direction.

Do not use the harsher bench’s original sizing bar (which required a \$160M baseline print) — that was calibrated to a \$27.88 entry and is too demanding at 8.5× baseline. The harsher bench’s own deeper rail is more relevant: roughly **\$16**, about 7× enterprise value to baseline EBITDA, *with fifteen or more sessions of tape stabilization*, is where it said the name becomes interesting on price alone. That level is not currently armed and should be.

Catalyst dates:

Date	What	Confirmed?
2026-08-10	LINC Q2 — the sector-vs-execution discriminator	Occurred. Resolved: sector.
2026-11-18	FY26 year-end results and initial FY27 outlook — the decisive print	Unconfirmed (vendor-derived; no company release names it, and the fiscal year ends 9/30, so the year-end print has historically landed in early December)
2026-12-10	Alternative year-end print date if the November date is wrong	Unconfirmed
2027-02-03	Q1 FY27 results — the starts test ($\geq +12\%$)	Unconfirmed

The decisive test is the FY27 baseline guide at the year-end print. Everything before it is positioning.

ARMED SENSORS

(armed provisionally with this deck; session adjudication ratifies)

- price alert: fires below 16.0 (deck-provisional: Deeper rail from the harsher bench: ~7x EV/baseline EBITDA, valid only with 15+ sessions of tape stabi)
- filing watch: 8-K until 2027-02-27 (deck-provisional: FY26 year-end results and initial FY27 outlook: the FY27 baseline EBITDA guide (<\$150M = full exit) an)
- dated pack UTI|2026-12-10: UTI FY27 baseline guide (~Dec): HIT = baseline EBITDA guide >= \$150M (structural cut recovering) OR Q1 starts >= +12%. RESOLVE: python3 -m d
- dated pack UTI|2026-08-10: UTI: LINC Q2 — court trigger already passed and never resolved; raise strengthens the execution-gap leg, cut means sector not execution. (da
- dated pack UTI|2026-11-18: UTI: FY26 year-end results plus initial FY27 outlook; HIT = FY27 baseline EBITDA guide >= \$150M. Corrects the 2026-12-10 pack, which is roug
- dated pack UTI|2027-02-03: UTI: Q1 FY27 results — the starts test; >= +12% activates the flip path. Cannot resolve in December. (date confirmed=False)

What remains unverified

Stated plainly, because these are the things that would change the answer and we do not have them.

- **The street's FY27 numbers.** No post-cut consensus EBITDA or EPS, and no range. Without it we have a level judgment, not a divergence. This is the single largest gap in the file.
- **The 70% attribution.** The claim that roughly 70% of the full-year EBITDA reduction came from weak Q4 high-school-channel starts rests on secondary coverage. We did not read the transcript from the primary source. The written release's silence on the demand cause *is* confirmed from primary.
- **Operating cash flow reconciliation.** The pack's cash-flow tag and the figures used in analysis differ in concept and scale (\$22.96M versus \$97.33M for adjacent periods). Unresolved. Any cash-conversion argument built on this is provisional.
- **Whether the fourth-quarter cash flow lands.** The ~\$79.6M implied figure is arithmetic from the guide, not a forecast we have independently built.
- **Insider trade direction, post-crash.** Three Form 4s, no accompanying Rule 144 notices, EDGAR blocked. Could be buys; could be withholding.
- **Gainful-employment debt-to-earnings pass/fail.** Not determinable from the filings we have. Left open honestly by both benches.
- **Whether the active-student deceleration (+12.7% → +5.8%) is seasonal.** The seasonality tool was never run — the bench had no shell. Plausible, not confirmed.
- **The print date.** 2026-11-18 is vendor-derived. No company announcement names it, and the fiscal year ends 30 September, so early December is historically as likely. Both dates are armed for this reason.

- **Whether the answer-engine funnel shock is a level shift or a trend.** Two operators, one quarter, one named mechanism. That is a hypothesis with two data points, and we have no way to measure it directly.
- **Live price basis.** The gateway quote could not be independently re-pulled this session (permission not granted); the price rests on the pack quote cross-checked against a vendor daily series that agrees to the cent.

Bottom line: the harsher bench won the diagnosis and lost the verdict on one leg; the constructive bench won the tape and the peer read and lost the verdict overall. The adjudication declined, and the decline holds. We do nothing at \$21.13. At \$21.00 we re-derive — and the first question in that re-derivation is not “is it cheap” but “has it stopped falling.”

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